

Department of neurosciences

Levetiracetam drug information

Drug/brand names

- Levetiracetam
- Keppra
- Desitrend

Formulation

Levetiracetam is available as 250mg, 500mg, 750mg and 1000mg tablets

A liquid formulation is available (100mg/ml) usually in 150ml or 300ml bottles

Granules in sachets– 250mg sachet, 500mg sachet, 1000mg sachet (not routinely stocked at Addenbrooke's hospital)

An injectable formulation is also available but only for use in a clinical or hospital setting.

Uses

Levetiracetam is used to reduce seizure frequency and severity in people who have epilepsy. It is now used for a variety of seizure types and may be used alone or alongside other antiepileptic medication.

Side effects (the list of side effects is not exhaustive, please refer to product literature for full list)

Levetiracetam is generally well tolerated. The side effects are dose related. The higher the dose, the more side effects one would experience. These side effects also tend to decrease over time and are only occasionally a significant problem. Side effects may reduce or disappear on reducing the dose of the medication. In the event of any of these side effects, contact the epilepsy nurse (contact details are at the end of the leaflet), or your GP.

Common side effects include;

- drowsiness or sleepiness
- headache, dizziness or lethargy
- nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea or indigestion
- some patients experience a change in mood and behaviour and can become aggressive
- muscle weakness and aches
- rash

- common cold or runny nose

Rarely reported side effects;

- All antiepileptic medication can cause feelings of depression, or severe mood changes. If you experience any of these please contact your specialist.
- The dose of levetiracetam may need to be altered in those patients with kidney problems.
- Levetiracetam can cause double or blurred vision and memory problems.
- Some patients may have altered liver enzymes; you will be monitored for this with blood tests if needed.
- Fluctuation in weight
- Hair loss

Contraception

There are no reports to indicate that levetiracetam affects the contraceptive pill. Other methods of contraception such as injections, coil etc. may also be used.

Pregnancy and breastfeeding

Inform your doctor before you conceive so that appropriate advice may be given. The effects of levetiracetam in pregnancy are not yet known; the manufacturer advises against taking levetiracetam during pregnancy.

Once you are pregnant, it is generally too late to make changes to medication. We recommend you take folic acid 5mg daily from at least twelve weeks prior to conception until the end of week 12 of pregnancy.

Levetiracetam passes into breast milk, the manufacturer advises against use whilst breastfeeding. Please seek advice from your epilepsy specialist nurse with regards breastfeeding.

You may need to have blood tests to monitor levels of levetiracetam in the blood during pregnancy.

Drug interactions

Levetiracetam is known to increase carbamazepine levels, if you need to take both together you will be monitored closely.

Inform your doctor or pharmacist that you are taking levetiracetam before starting any new medications.

Aspirin and paracetamol can be safely taken with levetiracetam.

Other useful information

- You can take levetiracetam at the same time as you take other medication. Do not stop taking your medication suddenly and without consultation with your doctor.
- There are no specific storage requirements for the tablets; it is advised to keep the liquid out of direct sunlight.
- Keep a record of your seizures when you start any new medication. This will help to determine future drug dosages.
- If you miss a dose, take it as soon as you remember but do not take two doses at the same time or within six hours of each other.

Contact details

If you have any questions or concerns, please contact the epilepsy nurse specialist on 01223 217992.

The information on this leaflet is not exhaustive. Please refer to the patient information leaflet prepared by the manufacturer of your drug which can be found in the medicine packaging.



We are a smoke-free site: smoking will not be allowed anywhere on the hospital site. For advice and support in quitting, contact your GP or the free NHS stop smoking helpline on 0800 169 0 169.

Other formats:



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Document history

Authors	Erica Chisanga.
Pharmacist	Frances Smith
Department	Cambridge University Hospitals NHS Foundation Trust, Hills Road, Cambridge, CB2 0QQ www.cuh.org.uk
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